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SCAN TO
WATCH

The tears would not stop.
His right hand went to his face, then the left one too.
The tears still would not stop.
He rearranged the pieces on the board, where the battle had just ended on such a stunning note, in a manner perhaps nobody could have imagined. His eyes were still wet.
Then he smiled.
The smile became broader.
Up went his arms in the air.
He must have found it hard to believe. Posterity will find it hard to believe.

But it is true. D. Gukesh is the World chess champion.
At 18.

It is one of the greatest stories in sport of our time.
Here was a boy who few people imagined would even be there for the World championship match. He had made it to the Candidates tournament — the qualifying event to determine the challenger for the championship — at the last minute.

For that, he had to win the Chennai Masters tournament in his hometown. For that, a tournament had to be there. It may have been arranged almost as an afterthought. But he still had to win it.

After winning the tournament a year ago, he played at the Candidates in Toronto. He wasn't the strongest of candidates in the Canadian city. In a field of eight, he was seeded sixth.

But he came out on top, ahead of such strong, experienced men like Fabiano Caruana, Hikaru Nakamura, Ian Nepomniachtchi and Alireza Firouzja. He wasn't even the highest seeded among the three Indians: that was another Chennai teenager, R. Praggnanandhaa.

But Gukesh emerged as the champion in April after drawing with Nakamura in the final round. He finished a clear first, half a point ahead of his nearest rivals — Nakamura, Nepomniachtchi and Caruana, who tied for second place.

Now, he had seven months to prepare. And what followed was preparation in the best way possible.

He was lucky on many counts.

He had a sponsor in WestBridge Capital, whose co-founder Sandeep Singhal's motto for the World championship was — as he told *Sportstar* shortly after Gukesh's triumph — "Whatever it takes." So Gukesh got the coach he wanted, the Seconds he wanted, the mental coach he wanted, and the place where he wanted to train.

Cost was not going to be a factor. Singhal was sure about it.

And Gukesh also had Viswanathan Anand as his mentor, a living legend with the experience of playing the World championship matches for two decades and being the champion five times. Grzegorz Gajewski, the man who has worked with Anand for the World championship, led the formidable support team of Gukesh. Among the Seconds were the world's top players, such as Jan-Krzysztof Duda and Vincent Keymer from overseas, and the experienced Indian P. Harikrishna.

Paddy Upton, who played a role in India winning the 2011 World Cup and the men's hockey bronze medal at the Olympics this year, was also roped in as a mental coach. That happened after Singhal had a chat with Gukesh; they wondered if there was anything else apart from chess that could give even the slightest of advantages.

Days were spent on training, on opening theory especially, and playing practice games in speed chess, which would have mattered if the match had gone to tiebreakers. And speed chess was the area Ding Liren was deemed to have an edge: he had more experience, and he was ranked much higher than Gukesh in both rapid and blitz chess.

So every base had been covered before the match kicked off in Sentosa, a small island off Singapore's southern coast. But there was a rude awakening for Gukesh. He lost in the opening game. And he had white pieces.

Of the two colours in chess, white is usually considered more favourable, and you are expected to win more with white than black. A draw with black is considered more important than with white. A win with black carries a little more weight.

And it was Ding who dealt the first